

a logo that has strong references to the DNA), and there are some almost-insurmountable peaks that Vijay Chandru is looking forward to scaling in the field of bioinformatics and chemo-informatics. He has already reached some summits, like inventing the Simputer, a simplified hand-held computer.

Today, Strand Life Sciences (SLS) is among

company's model is simple. It makes money from products and consultation, and in turn, spends that money on research.

For Chandru, an honorary professor at Bangalore's National Institute of Advanced Studies, it was not easy to let go of the secure cushion of a teaching job at the IISc and start his own thing. But he has always done what he strongly believes in. Son of a civil servant and grandson of one of the Tamil cinema's leading lights, B. Narsimha Reddi—a Dadasaheb Phalke Award winner—Chandru completed his Ph.D from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and taught for a decade in the US till the early 1990s when, on a visit to the country, he realised this is where he belonged. Back in India, the country's straitjacketed approach to research and Delhi's labyrinthine bureaucracy frustrated him.

Along with colleagues Ramesh Hariharan, Swami Manohar, and V. Vinay, he started a perceptual computing lab, PerCoLat, where they finally designed the Simputer. In March 1999, Ratan Tata, at a meeting with the faculty of IISc, asked why the institution had not been able to foster entrepreneurship the way Stanford or MIT had. The meeting was catalytic and in less than a year, Chandru and three of his colleagues were asked to launch two companies—Strand Genomics (later renamed Strand Life Sciences) and PicoPeta Simputers (which developed the Simputer). The Simputer was an attempt to bridge the urban-rural divide in terms of information access. Its primary aim was to help in rural banking and microfinance. Of course, with a plethora of advanced hand-held communication devices now available, the Simputer has outlived its utility, but till now, about 5,000 units of the device have been sold and are in use.

As for SLS, it hasn't lost sight of its basic purpose. "We are a role model for academic start-ups in India and need to maintain an elevated level of compliance with best practices in governance," says Chandru. He also believes that his company provides an honourable platform for creating employment and an opportunity for talented young engineers and scientists to carry out indigenous research. SLS's tiny office in Bangalore has managed to do great things because it has realised that it is important to place people above institutions. It's the building block of great science. And an even better world. ■

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the country's leading *in silico* (totally computer-aided research) biotech companies, which deals with a wide array of pharmaceutical and computational research. Chandru, an Indian Institute of Science (IISc) professor, quit the job in December 2005, and completely devoted himself to SLS. The company has a dedicated team of 100 scientists, creating solutions that help in revolutionising medical, chemical, biological and computational research in the country. Of them, 55 per cent are computer engineers and about 40 per cent hail from India's sharpest technical institutes like IISc and the IITs, with Ph.Ds and other advanced degrees. With an annual turnover of Rs 24 crore, the company spends around 20 per cent of its earnings on research and development.

It is almost impossible to quantify the impact Chandru's company has made on people. About 5,000 scientists use the data analysis and data mining products that SLS has invented under its platform Avadis. It has also tied up with Agilent, a global technology leader in communications, electronics, life sciences and chemical analysis to develop a software called the GeneSpring which helps in the field of gene expression analysis.

About 25 per cent of the company's resources and time are spent on pharmaceutical research, which offers customised solutions to scientific problems. Their research is so strong that even some American drug companies prefer to outsource their pre-clinical trials to SLS. The